



» **SPORTSTAR
OF THE YEAR**

Proud moment: Sheetal Devi (centre) receiving the coveted Sportstar of the Year and Moment of the Year honours at the Sportstar Aces Awards in Mumbai. THE HINDU PHOTO LIBRARY

Shattering the glass ceiling

The nation was **captivated** by videos from the Hangzhou Asian Para Games showcasing the young girl effortlessly lifting the compound bow with her feet, using her mouth to hold the arrow's bit, and consistently hitting the centre of the target board.

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The Sheetal Devi story is one of two journeys, two people, and two destinies. On one side, there is a little girl born with phocomelia, a rare congenital condition due to which one's limbs are underdeveloped or absent, thereby limiting, to a great extent, the 'normalcy' her life would allow. On the other, there is a steely-eyed

archer who uses her feet to wield the bow and arrow, hitting the bullseye time and time again.

In 2023, Sheetal became the world record holder in the women's doubles event at the Para Worlds, while at the World Archery Para Championships, she clinched a silver medal, making her the first female armless archer to do so. She ended the year with a world no. 1 ranking in

the women's open category. The para archer from Loidhar, a small village in the Kishtwar district of Jammu and Kashmir, got the country to sit up and take notice when her exploits at the Hangzhou Asian Para Games saw her win three medals (two golds and a silver). The nation was captivated by videos from the tournament showcasing the young girl effortlessly lifting the compound